

Intent Mapping for Risk Detection

Author: Lakshmi Sagar SP

Data Safety Disclaimer

This framework is **fully abstracted**.

- No real customer data
- No identifiers
- No internal thresholds
- No proprietary systems

It is intended to demonstrate **methodology and thinking**, not expose sensitive information.

Purpose of the Framework

This framework provides a **structured method** to convert raw transactional activity into **intent-based risk understanding and controllable detection logic**. It was designed to address a common gap in fraud and AML systems:

- Risk often emerges through **sequences of behaviour over time**, not isolated anomalies.
 - By focusing on **behavioural progression and intent**, this framework enables earlier, more precise, and more explainable detection.
-

Core Idea

Instead of analysing transactions one by one, the framework:

1. Abstracts transactions into **behavioural signals**
2. Groups signals into **phases**
3. Infers **intent** from phase-wise behaviour
4. Converts intent into **detection hypotheses and rules**

This ensures every investigation contributes to **system-level learning**, not just case resolution.

Step 1: Behavioural Signal Extraction

Raw transactions are converted into **simple behavioural flags** that describe what is happening, not who is involved or how much money moved.

Examples of Behavioural Flags

- **Dormancy Break** – Account becomes active after a long inactive period
- **Burst Activity** – Multiple transactions in a short window
- **FIFO / Self-routing** – Rapid credit → debit cycles
- **Unknown Counterparty Spike** – Sudden increase in unfamiliar senders
- **Cash-out Proxy** – Rapid withdrawal following inflow
- **Device / Environment Change** – Sudden change in access context
- **Inactivity Patch** – Deliberate low activity after action

At this stage:

- Absolute values are ignored
- Identities are abstracted
- Only **patterns and transitions** matter

The output is a **timeline of flagged events**, not raw transactions.

Step 2: Behaviour Decomposition into Phases

Flagged events are grouped into **behavioural phases**. A **phase** represents a time segment where the account shows a **stable pattern of behaviour**.

Phase Design Principles

- Combine adjacent events with similar behaviour
- Split phases when behaviour meaningfully changes
- Merge minor noise into dominant phases
- Aim for **3–6 phases per account**

Each phase captures:

- Dominant behavioural flags
- Duration and stability
- Whether behaviour is escalating, cooling off, or repeating

This converts noisy timelines into a **readable behavioural story**.

Step 3: Intent Mapping

Each phase is mapped to a **likely intent**, forming an **Intent Map**.

Structure

Each phase answers:

- What was the dominant behaviour?
- What was the likely intent?
- Was this testing, execution, evasion, or maintenance?
- What is the most likely next action?

An intent map typically includes:

- Phase boundaries
- Behaviour summary
- Inferred intent
- Risk assessment
- Expected next scenario

The intent map becomes a **narrative explanation** of how risk evolved over time.

Step 4: Rule & Hypothesis Generation

Every completed intent map must produce **at least one detection hypothesis**.

Rule Design Principles

- Use **2–3 strong behavioural flags**, not many weak ones
- Prefer **relative patterns** over static thresholds
- Focus on **controllability** (precision vs false positives)
- Describe expected behaviour, not just conditions

Typical Rule Outputs

- Objective (what the rule should detect)
- Applicable behaviour or persona
- Core logic (flag combinations)
- Expected detection behaviour
- False-positive risk assessment

This ensures investigations directly improve **preventive detection systems**.

Key Design Principles

- *Intent over anomaly*
 - *Sequence over snapshot*
 - *Behaviour change over absolute values*
 - *Explainability over black-box scoring*
 - *Human-in-the-loop for high-risk decisions*
-

Outcomes of Using This Framework

- *Standardise how investigations are analysed*
- *Reduce analyst subjectivity*
- *Convert cases into reusable detection logic*
- *Detect structured misuse earlier*
- *Improve precision while limiting over-blocking*

Most importantly, it creates a **feedback loop**: Investigations → Intent → Rules → Fewer future cases
